



MANEESH AGNIHOTRI

States **UTTAR PRADESH**

THE STATUES OF KANSHI RAM AND MAYAWATI HAVE COST THE EXCHEQUER RS 3.37 CRORE AND RS 3.49 CRORE RESPECTIVELY

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Mayawati's plans to immortalise herself by building statues are under fire as the Supreme Court steps in over the misuse of public money

| By Farzand Ahmed |

A picture, as the saying goes, tells a thousand words but larger-than-life-size statues perhaps tell a million and more. At least that's what Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Mayawati seems to believe. She had always had a fascination for herself, which during her fourth term in office has transformed into nothing short of overbear-

ing narcissism. Among the living, no leader, barring North Korea's Kim Jong-il, shares her passion for having their own statues sculpted. In Lucknow alone, there are five parks and memorials spread over 413 acres of prime land with several bronze and marble statues of Mayawati while an equal number of parks have similar statues of the BSP founder Kanshi Ram. Besides, 60 statues of the elephant, the BSP party symbol, have been put up in

these parks, costing the exchequer Rs 52.2 crore. The costs of the Kanshi Ram and Mayawati statues have been proportionately less, at Rs 3.37 crore and Rs 3.49 crore. Worse, to build her dream projects, the state Government bulldozed nearly a dozen government buildings, including six huge estate department bungalows, a massive sports stadium, among others. Some of the buildings housed rare records and ancient maps of the rivers and canals in